Robert. He was thinking of the supreme trials that his brother had endured in the course of his life: the illness that almost killed him; the shock on learning of the death of his older brother, Joseph; the loss of his infant son, Patrick. “I think these few minutes were the time of gravest concern to the President,” wrote Robert later.[19]

Kennedy was bracing himself for the worst—a likely sinking of a Soviet ship, the Soviet imposition of a Berlin blockade, an American airlift to save the city, and the Soviet shooting down of American planes. “What do we do then?” he asked the gathering. McNamara’s deputy, Paul Nitze, began to enumerate possible responses: “We’ve got our fighters up in the corridor and we try to shoot down their planes.” Nitze was still continuing his exposition when McCone reentered the Cabinet Room. “What have you got, John?” “These ships are all westbound, all inbound for Cuba,” responded McCone. He did not know where the ships were at the moment but knew that “they either stopped them or reversed the direction.” And so the ships were moving away from Cuba. Among the six listed by McCone were the *Kimovsk* and the *Gagarin*.

“We are eyeball to eyeball, and I think the other fellow just blinked,” whispered Dean Rusk to McGeorge Bundy when he heard that the Soviets ships had turned away from Cuba. “Well, let’s just say that, if this report is accurate, then we’re not going to do anything about these ships close to Cuba,” suggested Kennedy. “We’re not planning to grab any ship that is not proceeding toward Cuba,” said McNamara, echoing the president. Robert Kennedy had abandoned his previous position that the ships had to be stopped that day no matter where they were heading. “Well, will that information get to the Navy?” he asked, reacting to McNamara’s statement. For once he and Rusk were in agreement. “Yeah, we better be sure the Navy knows that they’re not supposed to pursue these ships,” said Rusk, supporting the younger Kennedy. “The meeting droned on,” remembered Robert Kennedy. “But everyone looked like a different person. For a moment the world had stood still, and now it was going around again.” The order to attack the ships was recalled.[20]

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